

Astonishment Report

Study Abroad – Japan (EF Tokyo)

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CMGT

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EF International Language Campus Tokyo

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Introduction

From January until June 2026, I participated in a study abroad programme at EF International Language Campus Tokyo in Japan. My primary goal was to improve my Japanese language skills through immersion in the language and culture. I chose Japan because I have been interested in the country for many years and wanted to experience daily life there instead of only visiting as a tourist.

The programme lasted approximately five months and was located in Shibuya, one of Tokyo's most famous and vibrant districts. During my stay, I attended the intensive Japanese language course, participated in cultural activities, travelled throughout Japan, and met students from all over the world.

This report describes my preparations, experiences at the school, daily life in Tokyo, cultural differences between Japan and the Netherlands, and the personal benefits I gained from this exchange.

Chapter 1: Preparations

Preparing for a study period abroad can seem overwhelming at first, but my experience was relatively straightforward due to the support provided by EF.

Registration Process

The registration process through EF was simple. Throughout the process, I was assigned contact persons who could answer questions about travel, accommodation, and the study programme. Communication was clear and most information was provided well in advance.

Visa

As a Dutch citizen, I did not need a student visa for my stay. Instead, I entered Japan on a tourist visa. Since Dutch citizens can only stay in Japan for a limited period under this arrangement, EF organised a group trip to South Korea after approximately three months. Upon returning to Japan, a new tourist visa was granted, allowing me to continue my studies.

Financial Requirements

I was never asked to provide proof of finances by Japanese immigration authorities. However, you should make sure you have enough saved for accommodation, transportation, food, and personal expenses.

Flights

You can either book the flights through EF or arrange it independently. I chose to organise my own flights because it gave me more flexibility and control over my travel arrangements.

Accommodation

EF Tokyo offers several accommodation options.

The standard option included in the tuition fee is a homestay. You typically share a room with another student and live relatively close to Tokyo.

My first accommodation was a homestay in Gamo, Saitama. The house was shared by six students in total. Although it was called a homestay, the host family did not live with us. Instead, they delivered meals and maintained contact when necessary. In practice, it felt more like a student house.

One disadvantage was that cleaning responsibilities depended on all the students living in the house, which sometimes led to less-than-ideal living conditions.

After approximately two and a half months, I moved to the EF residence. Although the room was relatively small and more expensive, I preferred having my own space which also gave me more freedom.

Insurance, Clothing, and Packing

You should arrange proper travel and health insurance before departure. Japan is generally a very safe country, but unexpected situations can always occur.

EF offers its own travel insurance package for students studying abroad. However, I decided to use my own travel insurance because it already provided all the coverage I needed for my stay in Japan. I would recommend that future students compare the coverage and costs of both options before making a decision.

Regarding clothing, Tokyo experiences all four seasons. During my stay, temperatures ranged from cold winter weather in January to warm and humid conditions in June. One thing I noticed is that I did not really need my heavy winter coat during winter in Japan. Almost all buildings and public transport are heavily heated, often to the point where it feels very warm indoors, so a thick coat quickly becomes unnecessary once you are inside.

I also noticed some cultural differences in clothing during warmer periods. For example, Japanese people generally dress more conservatively compared to what I am used to in the Netherlands. Short jeans or very casual summer clothing were less common. At the same time, the sun in Japan can already feel quite strong early in the year, and once summer approaches, the heat and humidity increase very quickly and become intense.

Because of this, it is important to bring layered clothing that can be adjusted easily between outdoor and indoor environments.

I would also recommend bringing:

- A power adapter as Japan uses the type A (and sometimes type B) power outlets. The standard voltage is 100V.
- Comfortable walking shoes as you will walk a lot in this city.
- Any important medications.
- A debit or credit card that works internationally.
 - You do not need to bring cash beforehand as that is often more expensive than getting cash out of the ATM in Japan.

Overall, preparation was relatively easy thanks to EF's guidance and support.

Chapter 2: The university

Programme Structure

My primary focus was learning Japanese. I followed the intensive Japanese programme, which consisted of regular Japanese classes combined with SPIN classes.

Each term lasted six weeks. During every term, students selected four SPIN classes according to their interests and learning goals.

Examples of some SPIN classes I followed included:

- Hiragana
- Katakana
- Basic Kanji
- Japanese grammar

This flexibility allowed me to focus on areas where I wanted to improve.

Teaching Style

One aspect that immediately stood out was that classes were conducted entirely in Japanese from the first day.

Although many teachers could understand and speak English, they intentionally used Japanese as much as possible. This immersive approach initially felt challenging, but it significantly accelerated language acquisition.

Classes contained a maximum of sixteen students, creating an interactive and supportive learning environment.

The school used the Marugoto textbook series, consisting of:

- A Grammar book
- A Katsudoo (activities) book
 - This book focuses on practical communication and speaking/listening skills.
- A Rikai (understanding) book
 - This book focuses on grammar, vocabulary, reading, and deeper language comprehension.

Each term the class was assigned a main teacher responsible for the core lessons. SPIN classes were often taught by different teachers, allowing students to experience different teaching styles.

International Environment

One of the most enjoyable aspects of studying at EF was meeting people from all over the world. Students stayed for varying lengths of time, ranging from a few weeks to several months like I did.

While this meant that classmates occasionally changed, the overall class atmosphere remained welcoming and friendly.

Student Support

The support provided by EF was excellent.

Different staff members specialised in:

- Accommodation
- Academic matters
- Activities and excursions
- General student support

The reception desk was always available to answer questions related to both school and life in Japan.

This support system made it easy to solve problems and helped me and a lot of other students feel comfortable in a foreign country.

Sustainability

Japan places a strong emphasis on waste separation and recycling. We were expected to sort waste into multiple categories. While this system can initially be confusing, it contributes to a cleaner environment and encourages sustainable behaviour.

The school itself also promoted responsible use of materials and maintained clean facilities.

Advice for Future Students

You should be prepared to use Japanese immediately, even if you only possess basic knowledge. It may feel intimidating at first, but immersion is one of the most effective ways to learn a language.

Additionally, you should actively participate in activities organised by EF, as these provide excellent opportunities to make friends and explore Japan.

Chapter 3: Daily life

Daily life in Tokyo was both exciting and surprisingly convenient.

Food

Japanese food quickly became one of my favourite aspects of living abroad.

Some foods I particularly enjoyed included:

- Ramen
- Soba
- Udon
- Tonkatsu
- Okonomiyaki
- Curry
- Onigiri
- Gyoza
- Melon pan

Lunch generally costed me around 1,000 yen, while dinner was also approximately 1,000 yen. Including snacks and drinks, daily food expenses for me were usually between 3,000 and 3,500 yen.

Students staying in homestays also receive breakfast and dinner each day, which I didn't receive for the latter half of my stay as I moved into the residence during that time.

Transportation

Tokyo's public transportation system is one of the most efficient systems I have ever used.

The train and metro networks make it possible to travel almost anywhere quickly and reliably. Compared to the Netherlands, public transportation felt very punctual and affordable.

My transportation costs were approximately 700 yen per day for commuting to and from school.

Shopping

Tokyo offers countless shopping opportunities, but I did not necessarily go shopping all the time. Instead, I often combined exploring the city with visiting various kinds of stores and districts.

Some places I visited include Loft, which sells stationery, school supplies, souvenirs, and lifestyle products, and Don Quijote (Donki), which offers a very wide range of affordable items. I also visited the Pokémon Center, which was a highlight for me as a fan of Pokémon.

In addition, I went to Uniqlo for clothing, and I spent time in Akihabara, where I explored many anime, manga, and general “geek culture” stores. These areas were especially interesting because they felt quite different from typical shopping districts in the Netherlands.

Overall, I was more focused on sightseeing and exploring various parts of Tokyo than on shopping itself, but the variety of stores made it easy to discover new places naturally during my time there.

Cost of Living

The cost of living depends heavily on lifestyle choices.

For basic expenses, you should budget approximately:

- €600 per month for food
- Additional transportation costs (costs depends on where you stay)
- Entertainment and shopping expenses

Students who enjoy travelling, collecting souvenirs, or exploring Japan extensively should budget significantly more.

Activities and Excursions

One of the highlights of the programme was participating in organised activities and excursions. These trips gave me the opportunity to explore various parts of Tokyo and Japan while spending time with friends from all over the world. They also created many memorable experiences and helped strengthen friendships throughout the exchange.

We visited many shrines and temples throughout Tokyo. These visits were especially interesting to me because we do not have anything similar in the Netherlands. I found it fascinating to see how present religion and tradition still are in everyday Japanese life, and how these places are respected and maintained.

Another highlight was the organised bus tours to Nikko and Hakone. Both locations offered beautiful natural scenery and a peaceful atmosphere compared to the busy city of Tokyo. In Hakone, I visited an onsen for the first time. I immediately enjoyed the experience, as it was very relaxing and unlike anything I had done before.

We also travelled to several major cities, including Osaka, Kyoto, and Nara. Each of these cities had its own unique atmosphere, with Kyoto and Nara especially standing out because of their historical and cultural significance.

A visit to Mount Fuji was another memorable experience. Although we did not climb the mountain, we travelled to the 5th station, which still offered impressive views. During this trip, we also had the opportunity to make our own noodle dish in a nearby restaurant, which was a fun and interactive experience.

Finally, we visited Kamakura and Enoshima, which were both very scenic coastal areas. The combination of ocean views, temples, and relaxed atmosphere made this one of the more peaceful and enjoyable excursions.

Overall, these activities were not only enjoyable but also gave me a much deeper appreciation of Japan's cultural, historical, and natural diversity.

Chapter 4: Culture

According to Hofstede's cultural dimensions, Japan and the Netherlands share certain similarities but also differ in important ways.

One of the most noticeable differences I experienced was the importance of social harmony in Japan. Japanese society places great value on respecting others and avoiding behaviour that may inconvenience people around them.

A clear example is public transportation. Even when trains are completely crowded, passengers generally remain silent. In the Netherlands, conversations on public transport are common. In Japan, maintaining a calm and quiet environment demonstrates consideration for others.

Another difference is the way people queue. In Japan, people form orderly lines almost everywhere, whether waiting for trains, elevators, shops, or restaurants. This creates a sense of organisation and fairness that I found very pleasant.

Punctuality is also taken extremely seriously. If a meeting is scheduled for a certain time, arriving five minutes early is often considered normal. This contrasts with Dutch culture, where arriving exactly on time is usually acceptable.

Politeness is another aspect that stood out. Japanese people consistently use respectful language and show consideration towards others. Respect for elders is deeply integrated into daily interactions and can be observed in both personal and professional situations.

One cultural aspect that I particularly appreciated was the convenience of everyday life. Convenience stores can be found almost everywhere and are often open twenty-four hours a day. Whether I needed food, drinks, snacks, or household items, a store was usually only a few minutes away.

Although I already had considerable knowledge about Japan before arriving, experiencing these cultural differences firsthand was quite different from simply reading about them. Living in Japan allowed me to understand why these behaviours exist and how they contribute to the smooth functioning of society.

When discussing cultural differences with fellow students and local people, many Japanese individuals expressed surprise at how direct Dutch communication can be. Dutch people generally value honesty and straightforwardness, while Japanese communication often prioritises harmony and indirect expression.

Neither approach is necessarily better than the other; they simply reflect different cultural values. Understanding these differences helped me become more aware of my own communication style and improved my ability to interact with people from different cultural backgrounds.

Overall, my experience largely confirmed Hofstede's theories regarding collectivism, uncertainty avoidance, and long-term orientation in Japanese culture. However, living in Japan also demonstrated that cultural differences are nuanced and cannot always be fully explained by theoretical models alone.

Chapter 5: Personal reflection

Looking back, my study abroad experience was one of the most valuable experiences of my life.

Five Most Important Benefits

1. Improved Japanese Language Skills

My Japanese improved significantly during my stay. Before travelling to Japan, I could only understand and use limited Japanese. By the end of the programme, I could communicate much more confidently and had learned to read and write Hiragana, Katakana, and basic Kanji.

2. Increased Independence

Living abroad required me to manage housing, transportation, finances, and daily responsibilities independently. This helped me become more self-reliant and confident.

3. International Friendships

I met people from many different countries and cultures. These friendships were one of the most rewarding aspects of the exchange and provided perspectives I would never have gained otherwise.

4. Cultural Understanding

Living in Japan gave me a deeper understanding of Japanese culture than any book, documentary, or short holiday ever could.

5. Personal Growth

Being outside my comfort zone for several months challenged me in many ways. As a result, I became more adaptable, open-minded, and confident.

Would I Do It Again?

Absolutely! If I had the opportunity, I would go back to Japan immediately. Studying abroad in Japan exceeded my expectations in almost every way. The combination of language learning, cultural immersion, travel opportunities, and personal development made the experience incredibly rewarding.

What I Wish I Had Known in Advance

If I could give advice to future students, I would tell them not to worry too much about speaking Japanese perfectly before arriving. You learn far more by using the language every day than by studying it only from textbooks.

I would also recommend budgeting carefully, as Tokyo offers endless opportunities to spend money on food, travel, hobbies, and souvenirs.

Most importantly, I would encourage future students to say yes to new experiences. Join activities, explore various places, talk to new people, and take advantage of every opportunity.

Final Advice

My advice to future exchange students is simple: take the opportunity to go.

Studying abroad in Japan was a once-in-a-lifetime experience that allowed me to grow academically, culturally, and personally. The memories, friendships, and skills I gained will stay with me for the rest of my life.